

tion only. This means that members of Orkut had to send out invitations to others so they could sign up. This ensured that new members at least had one person as their friend on the site. This has changed. Now anyone can sign up to Orkut after creating a Google ID. If you already have a Gmail ID, you can enable Orkut by visiting the Google Services link on top of the Gmail account page. People signing up directly can invite their friends to join up and form a group.

Google IDs and Gmail ID

Google offers a host of services, all of which are the focus of this book. Gmail is the free e-mail service from Google. A Gmail ID is one that allows access to the e-mail service. To access some of Google's other services, you need to associate them with the Gmail ID. This way you can use all the services with a single ID. To associate services, use the "All my Services" link at the top of the Standard Gmail page.

If you do not have a Gmail ID, you can still use almost all Google services. For this you only need a Google ID which you can get by providing your existing, non-Gmail, e-mail ID. To access any service that asks for a Google ID, you provide the existing, non-Gmail, e-mail ID as username. For example, if you do not have a Gmail ID and your existing e-mail ID is boohoo@sify.com, you can sign up for a Google ID by providing boohoo@sify.com. To sign into any Google Service, the username to use will be boohoo@sify.com.

Conspicuously, a Google ID doesn't allow access to Gmail—which is still by invitation only; unlike every other Google Service.

The Google ID forms a central passport to all Google Services. This allows Google to track all your activities throughout the Google service umbrella, and helps them form a better-informed database of your likes and dislikes, which can be used to offer precisely-targeted advertising—which is Google's lifeline.

To understand Orkut, one needs to look at the process of forming and maintaining friendships and acquaintances. Briefly, step one is a formal introduction—what happens when you enter a new organisation; step two is the discovery of common interests—you find others who share your ideas; step three is continued interaction with selected people, possibly leading to friendship.

Orkut fuses two services—e-mail, and a forum / bulletin board. Both